dreaded and shadowy STF in his life, the lives of ordinary people in Kashmir, where his family lives. All we want, he said, is peace.

I had given him the petition drafted by me to read. I asked him if there was anything he wanted to say in addition to what I had mentioned. He only asked a question: 'Why is it that when the same role was attributed to me and Shoukat, he has been given ten years and I have been given the death penalty?' The answer, he said, was self-evident—Shoukat had top- class lawyers; he had none.

December 2006

Postscript, February 2007

On 12 January 2007, roughly a month after this article was written, and this book published, the Supreme Court of India dismissed Afzal's curative petition. This will have far-reaching consequences for thousands of people in this country. To send a man to his death without legal representation is not only unconstitutional but also barbaric. Why go through an elaborate trial if the accused is not represented by a lawyer? One might as well be judge, prosecutor, and counsel for the accused and pronounce judgment.

The law laid down by the Supreme Court visualizes the filing of a curative petition to cure a miscarriage of justice. That was done by Afzal—to no avail. Now, only the President of India can have the last word. We can only give opinions that there has been a gross miscarriage of justice.